

compromised due to its open source nature since anyone can view its source code and detect bugs in it. So you have to take extra measures to ensure the security of your Web page if you are dealing with sensitive data.

Fact: It is estimated that there are approximately 5 million PHP developers worldwide, which is a testament to its power.

Open source IDEs for PHP development

The choice of IDE plays an important role in the development of any program or application but this aspect is often neglected. A good and robust IDE comes packed with loads of features and packages to enable rapid development.

Automatic code generation, refactoring, organising imports, debugging, identifying dead code and indentation are some of the advantages a powerful IDE can provide. So let's take a look at some dominant open source IDEs that can be very useful in PHP development.

1. **NetBeans:** Most of you must be aware of NetBeans in Java development but it can also be used for PHP development. The biggest advantage of NetBeans is that it supports many languages like English, Chinese, Japanese, etc., and can be installed smoothly on any operating system. Some of the features that differentiate it from the rest are smart code completion, refactoring, try/catch code completion and formatting. It also has the capability to configure various PHP frameworks like Smarty, Doctrine, etc. You can download it from netbeans.org.
2. **Eclipse:** Eclipse tops the list of popular IDEs. If you have worked with Eclipse earlier, then you will feel at home using Eclipse PDT for PHP development. It can be downloaded from eclipse.org/pdt. Some of its features are syntax highlighting, debugging, code templates, validating syntax and easy code management through Windows Explorer. It is a cross-platform IDE and works on Windows, Linux and Mac OS. Since it is developed in Java, you must have it installed in your machine.
3. **PHPStorm:** PHPStorm, developed by JetBrains (the same company that developed IntelliJ IDEA for Java), is mainly used for professional purposes but is also available licence-free for students, teachers and open source projects. It has the most up-to-date set of features for rapid development since it provides support for leading front-end technologies like HTML5, CoffeeScript, JavaScript and Sass. It supports all the major frameworks available in the market like Symfony, CakePHP, Laravel and Zend, and can also be integrated with databases, version control software, rest clients and command line tools to ease the work of developers. A number of MNCs, like Wikipedia, Yahoo and Cisco, are making use of PHPStorm for PHP development. You can read more about PHPStorm at jetbrains.com/phpstorm.
4. **Sublime Text:** Sublime Text is basically a text editor, but it can be converted into a PHP IDE by installing various

available packages. It is known for its sleek, feature-rich and lightweight interface. It is also supported on all operating systems. Some of the packages which can be used to convert it into an IDE are Sublime PHP Companion, PHPCS, codIntel, PHPDoc, Simple PHPunit, etc. It can be downloaded as open source from sublimetext.com.

5. **PHP Designer:** This IDE is only available for Windows users. It is very fast and powerful, with full support for PHP, HTML, JavaScript and CSS. It is used for fast Web development due to its features like intelligent syntax highlighting, object-oriented programming, code templates, code tips and debug manager, which are all wrapped into a sleek and intuitive interface that can also be customised according to various available themes. It also supports various JavaScript frameworks such as JQuery, ExtJs and Yui. An open source version of it is available and you can read more about it on its official website.
6. **NuSphere PHP IDE:** PHPED is the IDE developed by NuSphere, a Nevada based company which entered the market way back in 2001. The current available version of PHPED is 18.0 which provides support for PHP 7.0 and almost all PHP frameworks. This tool also has the ability to run unit tests for the developed projects and comes packaged with the support for all Web based technologies. You can download PHPED from NuSphere's website www.nusphere.com.
7. **Codebaster:** Codebaster also provides a free IDE for PHP development. Though it is not used too often, it is catching up fast. By downloading the free version, you get support for PHP, JS, HTML and CSS. It can be integrated with various frameworks such as Drupal, WordPress, Symfony and Yii. You can download it from www.codebaster.com.

Writing the first PHP program

Having read about PHP, its history and various IDEs, let's write our first PHP program and run it using XAMPP. Though there is no official information about the full form of XAMPP, it is usually assumed to stand for cross-platform (X), Apache (A), MariaDB (M), PHP (P) and Perl (P). XAMPP is an open source, widely used Web server developed by apachefriends.org, which can be used to create a local HTTP server on machines with a few clicks. We will also be using it in our tutorial below.



Figure 1: Apache service started on XAMPP control panel